

A Foretaste of the World to Come

A Proposal for Understanding the Essence and Purpose of the Sabbath

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A. Introduction

In shaping the face of Judaism, the Sabbath has taken on far-reaching significance: it constitutes both a central symbol on the national-historical plane and a positive commandment of immense weight on the halakhic plane. In practice, too, Sabbath time occupies a seventh of the entire life of a believing Jew, and it shapes the course of the week around it. A natural consequence of this is that the Sabbath is also the center of an almost endless body of engagement and creativity — in art, in literature, in halakha, in scholarship, in aggadah, in Kabbalah, in homiletics, and even in prophecy. It seems that there is no subject in the Jewish world that so many generations and thinkers have pondered and engaged with, and it seems that there is almost nothing that has not been said about it. It is also clear that there is no way to encompass all the worlds and the creative work that have arisen around the Sabbath.

If so, on the face of it, engaging with the essence of the Sabbath is a presumptuous undertaking beyond compare. Beyond the fact that it is quite likely that nothing new, not even half of something new, can be added on this subject, since everything has already been said and every direction of thought and definition has already been exhausted — worse still, from the opposite direction: it seems that almost any homiletical attempt or any spiritual definition of the Sabbath will sound credible and serious, and will be able to base itself on many sources, and on greater figures than the present writer who have already set out in this very direction before (for, as noted, they have already set out in many different, and at times even opposite, directions). From this vantage point, it seems there is no advantage or benefit at all in yet another spiritual engagement with the subject of the Sabbath.

Nevertheless, in this essay we will try to investigate the inner essence that the Torah attributes to this day, and, in effect, the reason and purpose of the commandment of the Sabbath.[1] We will present a key, a central point, through which all the components of the Sabbath can be seen as bound to a single course and a single purpose, and through which the Sabbath ought to be experienced in an existential sense. The attempt is not to illuminate some particular facet or point, but to find the central point that is the backbone of the entire subject. Of course, everything we write is said in the language of doubt and conjecture, with reservation against staking out overbearing, categorical claims; nevertheless, our sincere aim is to remain faithful and attuned to the sources and to the simple, basic intention of the Torah of Israel, with the help of Heaven.

B. The Method

Let us preface this with a comment on the method of inquiry into a broad subject or commandment.

The customary homiletical approach to such subjects is deductive (from the general to the particular)[2] — first some root idea develops, some unique illumination or perspective on a concept, and then the thinker clothes it upon the particulars, rereading the sources on the subject in light of the unique coloring and point of view he has found and established beforehand. Some of the sources fit this perfectly; some he reads in a "hasidic" manner of expansion and extension beyond what is embedded in the text itself;[3] and most of them he does not make use of at all, since they do not support the direction he has tried to show.

By contrast, there is an inductive approach (from the particular to the general). In this approach, even before some foundational idea has crystallized, the student sits and tries to gather as broad a collection as possible of sources touching on the subject — statements, verses, aggadot, halakhot, customs — and strives to encompass and become familiar with all of them. Only in the second stage does the student try to find an inner connection between the sources, and bend his mind to search out a shared conceptual root. Even after finding some inner key to the subject, he returns and examines it again in light of as broad a range as possible of individual sources on the subject, and if things do not come together well, he tries to generalize, to broaden the idea, to refine it, and even to change it considerably, until it fits honestly with all, or the great majority, of the particulars.

The advantage of the deductive approach is spiritual flight; thought is freed from the burden of detailed research and study, and so the preacher can more easily produce a general, elevated and meaningful idea. By contrast, in the inductive approach we receive a stronger sense of inner certainty and faithfulness to the sources, and a sense that the matter is not a castle built in thin air.

In this essay we have tried to measure ourselves by the criterion of inductiveness — that is, the creation of a general principle that fits as many particulars as possible. That said, we have not carried out a comprehensive, systematic, scientific research effort, nor have we burdened ourselves with all the sources that exist, or even most of them. One must navigate between the reliability of scientific induction and the spiritual flight of deductive homiletics; to fulfill the words of Kohelet, "It is good that you should take hold of this, and also from that withhold not your hand, for one who fears God shall come forth from them all" (7:18).

For this purpose it is fitting to define what kind of sources constitute the basis and skeleton of the idea, and which sources can serve as proof and reinforcement without being cardinal. We choose the primary sources on which to rely following the proposal of Rav Soloveitchik in his book *Worship of the Heart*,[4] where the Rav speaks of the fitting method for investigating a subject and reaching the depth of Jewish thought — through halakha,[5] aggadah, and the liturgy belonging to the subject. In addition to these three, we add, as a source of special constitutive weight, Scripture itself.

Let us now turn to the specific subject of this essay — the Sabbath. Although we have stressed that the idea crystallized out of the particulars, the presentation of the material will proceed methodically rather than in the form of a research-based analysis of a great number of sources.[6]

C. The Sabbath Passage in the Creation of the World

...And there was evening and there was morning, the sixth day. And the heavens and the earth were finished, and all their host. And on the seventh day God finished His work which He had made, and He rested on the seventh day from all His work which He had made. And God blessed the seventh day and sanctified it, because on it He rested from all His work which God had created to make.

Genesis 1:31–2:3

One who seeks to understand why the commandment of the Sabbath is granted such immense halakhic weight[7] ought to turn his heart first to examine these verses. The Sabbath first appears in the Torah immediately after the conclusion of the account of the creation of the world and of man. Apart from the commandment "be fruitful and multiply" — given immediately after the creation of man — this is the first commandment whose subject matter is mentioned in the Torah. True, no imperative language is used here, and it is also striking that the passage does not address man at all, but rather appears to tell a story unfolding in the higher worlds, without any manifest reference to creation. The Holy One sanctifies the day of the Sabbath, but according to the plain sense of the text no significance is given to this sanctity within the world of human beings, until the stage at which the people of Israel are commanded to keep the Sabbath. Nevertheless, it is clear that the very appearance of the subject at so early a stage, even if not as a command, shows its fundamental importance.

The fact that the Sabbath is first described as a metaphysical reality of blessing and holiness, legislated by God, without any normative instruction issuing from that description, carries real significance for understanding the Sabbath. Within the Jewish worldview there are different positions on the question of whether all halakhic definitions constitute an abstract, independent conceptual-legal world that is then clothed upon the details of reality, or whether halakha only reveals the actual reality hidden within the inner core of creation, concealed from man's physical-rational eye.[8] Take, for example, the question of what defines a forbidden object as forbidden. Is the entire definition of the prohibition simply that the Torah determines it to be forbidden, thereby creating upon it a legal "status" of prohibition, or is there a flaw in the actual reality of the object itself, as a result of which the Torah forbids it? An example of the application of the first possibility is the commandment of the sanctification of the new month, by force of which the court has the power to intercalate the months and thereby determine, in practice, when the prohibitions of labor on a festival will fall.[9] This feature has clear halakhic implications, and finds expression in the wording of the blessing "who sanctifies Israel and the seasons." [10]

The commandment of the Sabbath stands in absolute opposition to the position that sees the halakhic divine decree as a creative category, and this passage attests to that as clearly as a thousand witnesses. The passage teaches us that the Sabbath is a real, actual state of being, which does not depend on the scope of human concepts, and stands far above them. The Sabbath is a supernatural reality sealed for all eternity, entirely disconnected from human deeds and stratagems.

We wish to explain, in a somewhat innovative manner, God's cessation from all His work, as described in the passage. As is known, we do not understand at all concepts of doing and labor in relation to the Holy One. But the description of the Holy One's actions on the day of the Sabbath is far more difficult, since we are forced to apply to the Holy One simplistic concepts of time in order to say that there was a span of time — a "day" — in which He ceased from His labor and rested. If, after this Sabbath day (or even the day before), history begins, in which the Holy One is again described as acting, as supervising, and as renewing various actions in the world — then there is a span of time in which the Holy One is described as inactive, and this is difficult and unclear even according to the Torah's own metaphorical, anthropomorphic style.

On the basis of the well-known midrash of our Sages on the words "which God had created to make,"[11] we understand that the divine creation left room for human doing in the world, and that an inseparable part of the Holy One's charge to man is the development of the world, its refinement and its being brought to completion.[12] One can view the act of creation itself as a process that has not reached its final completion, a completion that the Holy One placed upon the shoulders of man from the day he was created. The world was created with a vision at its foundation, and with its purpose being the actualization of that full vision by the power of humanity's good choice and efforts.[13] One cannot say of the heavens and the earth that they have been completed,[14] since they are not yet complete. The whole of being is in a process of advancement, of return (teshuvah), and of climbing and striving toward the ideal — and the role of man is to bring the ideal into reality, "to repair the world" (tikkun olam), to bring the course of divine creation to its ultimate purpose. This reality — that all being and all the worlds that were created will arrive at a summit of infinite completeness beyond which there is no further advancement, and rest alone will remain — is described in the Torah as God's resting on the seventh day; the conclusion of creation.[15]

As we see it, the passage "vayechulu" ("and they were finished") describes an occurrence that does not lie behind us on the timeline, but, on the contrary — it describes the distant future, the end of days, the terminal point of the timeline and its meeting with eternity. The Sabbath appearing in the passage is an expression of that eschatological reality (the end of days) — "a day that is wholly Sabbath and rest for life everlasting." [16] It is of this reality, not yet actualized, that the Torah spoke in the three verses above. As it were, the Torah wrote all the outer bounds of the frame of the whole of history in chapter 1 — from the moment of "in the beginning" to the supreme end — as a kind of timeless preface to the Torah itself, which was given in human language and uses concrete terms familiar to us

from our own world. In this preface we encounter sublime terms that stand at the outer limit of our capacity for comprehension and imagination, terms with one foot in the infinite-transcendent hidden realm, and one foot sending rays of supernal understanding into the space of thought. Because this is a kind of supra-historical frame, the Torah returns and opens again: "These are the generations of the heavens and of the earth when they were created, in the day that the LORD God made earth and heaven." On the plain sense of the text it is unclear why the Torah returns again to describe creation, and especially the creation of man, and it is harder still to explain the gap between the two accounts. Many answers have been given to this question,[17] but according to our approach the repetition is understandable — the unit up to chapter 2, verse 3 is a distinct unit, describing things, as it were, from the eternal divine perspective, while from that point onward the Torah is written from a real, human perspective. This may explain the gap between the different accounts of creation — while in chapter 2 the act of creation is described in terms and from a point of view that a human being can absorb, in chapter 1 the description is in words murmuring a sealed secret, beyond the capacity of human perception and imagination.

If so, the Torah describes for us the ideal vision at the end of the days of creation as the seventh day, and calls this point of non-time-time "Sabbath." [18] After that we return to reading about the place and time at which the course of creation stands, from our point of view. The process of creation, up to its ultimate end and completion, is continued by man, who was created on the sixth day, and as long as we have not completed the task, we are still on the sixth day of creation — the creation of man has not yet been completed, and it will conclude at the time when man, who was created to continue God's path and to take up God's role in this world,[19] completes his task and arrives at the ultimate goal and full summit of being; then we shall enter the day of the Sabbath.

It follows from our words that the expression that appears in the Kiddush and in prayer — whose roots are planted in the passage above — that the Sabbath[20] is a "remembrance of the act of creation," takes on a different meaning: this is not a remembrance of a past event, as is commonly understood, but a remembrance of what is yet to be, a remembrance of the destination and direction of the entire course of events. By the power of that future, supreme Sabbath, in which humanity and being will arrive at complete repair and at their destiny to live eternal life in the shadow of God, the Holy One sanctifies the seventh days of this world and blesses them. And from this we derive the source of the commandment of the Sabbath day.

D. The Sabbath Day — Essence and Purpose

If we now sum up and crystallize our conclusions thus far, we can formulate concisely the unique essence of the Sabbath day.[21]

The Sabbath is a foretaste of the World to Come.[22] The essence of the day draws from the tremendous and sublime day of the future, the time of the coming of the final redemption and completion. Since that "end of days" is, in effect, the seventh day of the days of creation (for until that time we are still on the sixth day of creation, since the purpose for which man

was created has not yet been actualized), the Holy One sanctified all the days of Sabbath, to the end of all generations, with the supreme holiness of redemption. The meaning of the divine act of blessing and sanctification is that the Sabbath is a real glimmer of that ideal reality: the Sabbath of the future to come is reflected and glimpsed within the inner holiness of the Sabbath day. This is not merely a conceptual remembrance and symbol, but an ontological reality of the character of the seventh day.

However, we are not content merely to define its exclusive character, but seek to answer the normative question — what is the Sabbath day meant to bring about in our human world, how does it affect us, and what is its purpose in shaping our religious lives; in other words — what is the purpose of the Sabbath.

The connection between the commandment of the Sabbath and the act of creation appears also in the command concerning the Sabbath in the first version of the Ten Commandments:

Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy. Six days shall you labor and do all your work, but the seventh day is a Sabbath unto the LORD your God; you shall not do any work, you, nor your son, nor your daughter, your manservant, nor your maidservant, nor your cattle, nor your stranger that is within your gates. For in six days the LORD made heaven and earth, the sea, and all that in them is, and rested on the seventh day; therefore the LORD blessed the Sabbath day and hallowed it.

Exodus 20:8–11

From these verses it seems that the act of creation explains not only the essence of the Sabbath but also the reason for the commandment; it answers not only the question "what is the Sabbath?" but also the question "for what purpose is the Sabbath?"

The purpose of the Sabbath is, as stated, remembrance. The aim of keeping the Sabbath is to instill in the soul a deep remembrance of the ideal reality, with the knowledge that this is the purpose of the world and the direction of its advancement. The Sabbath is meant to resemble that reality as closely as possible, in order to grant a person living a life of toil a "taste" of redeemed existence, of the life of the World to Come. The aim of enabling this experience of existential trial within the tremendous eschatological event of the future is not only to grant psychic rest and to dispel the psychological tension of a challenge-laden existence, but also to break the normality and continuity of the ordinary flow of life, in order to remember for what purpose, to remember toward what end everything is heading and what is that destination which constitutes the whole of one's personal-religious present conduct. We live our lives out of a constant orientation, aspiration and expectation — toward return (teshuvah), toward the Divine Presence, toward redemption, toward repair and completion. Once a week we merit to taste the fruit's flavor, we merit to delight in the delight of ultimate, absolute devotion — and out of this supreme delight, which reminds us, in the depths of the experience, of the reason and purpose for which we came to live our lives on earth, we receive strength, energy and will to continue and carry out the sacred work of repairing the world and enthroning God's name on earth. Hope intensifies, longing

is aroused, the desire for life and the beauty of reality rise to renewed blossoming, and the practical life of "six days shall you labor" returns to being lit with a sweet light.

The real essence of the Sabbath and its ethical-halakhic purpose are bound together. We see redemption as a time when man will rest from all his toil, from all his struggles with the evil inclination and with the forces of wickedness, will sit with his crown upon his head and delight in the devotion and pleasure that are his by right and by the acquisition of labor, not as an act of grace and a free gift. This is a time in which there is no longer struggle, vision and advancement, nothing left to build, add and refine. This is the summit beyond which there is no further activity. The main characteristics of this eschatological picture are rest and delight. Even in the Sabbath we can identify these as the most basic components of the essence of the day and of the way it is to be kept.[23]

E. Applications

In the following section we will try to examine central details known to us about the Sabbath, both in the halakhic tradition and in the conceptual-cultural tradition. We will try to examine the relationship between the various points and the idea we have formulated above in defining the essence and purpose of the Sabbath — the essence of the Sabbath as a real foretaste of the World to Come, and the purpose of the Sabbath as an existential foretaste of the World to Come. As stated above, our aim in this essay is not only to propose a certain new idea regarding the Sabbath, but to explain how this point arises out of the totality of the particulars, and, in effect, weaves them into a commandment with a single central soul that has many direct particular expressions in practice.

The additional soul:[24] the idea of the additional soul (neshamah yeteirah) that a person receives from Israel's Sabbath at its entrance is understood by us as a special divine grace with a concrete purpose. On the Sabbath day a tremendous, dazzling light shines, the light of complete ideality, of a return to the life of the Garden of Eden. The human soul, coarsened by the life of matter and action of the six working days, is unable to contain so sublime a spiritual abundance without long preparation and gradualness. The spiritual-existential atmosphere of the Sabbath cannot be grasped by us with the ordinary composition of our psyche — for our intellect, our emotion, our spirit, our imagination and our body have no relation at all to such a reality. Our existential point of contact with the sublime light of the Sabbath of the future to come is through the pure soul, hidden day to day deep within the root of the spiritual personality. Were it not for the additional soul given to us on the Sabbath, the Sabbath would pass us by; we would be entirely unable to sense and grasp this spiritual atmosphere, and certainly the Sabbath would not be able to carry the taste of the existential experience and remembrance of the world's purpose through the six working days to come.

The prohibition of mourning, confession, and beseeching mercy: on the Sabbath we omit the central portion of the Amidah prayer, which consists of the blessings of petition. Likewise it is ruled, as a matter of halakha, that it is forbidden to cry out and beseech mercy on the Sabbath,[25] and it is also forbidden to say confession (viduy) and to mention sins.[26] The

reason for this is simple — halakha directs the Sabbath to resemble, as closely as possible, the complete ideal reality, so that we may experience the essence of the Sabbath in the full depth of the soul. In the ideal reality of the future to come there is nothing left to ask for — all the good is already actually present, and all the abundance is already flowing. Part of the unique experience of the Sabbath is to exist in a consciousness in which there is nothing left to yearn for, nothing to beseech mercy about; all the flaws of reality have been repaired, and nothing remains but to praise God's name, to give thanks before Him and to delight in the radiance of His presence. Similarly with the prohibition of confession — halakha uproots every sign of flaw and darkness from the character of the Sabbath, and tries to establish a reality as similar as possible to the reality of complete repair. On the Sabbath we behave as though we have already reached the state in which "He will swallow up death forever,"[27] as though sins had ceased from the earth and the wicked were no more; hence mourning and confession have no place.

Materiality: the Torah's attitude toward materiality is not hostile, but it is well aware of its dangers, and attaches importance to setting boundaries, control, restraint, self-discipline and even a reduction of material desires. The prohibitions of holiness come to remove from the permitted domain part of the objects of desire, in order to refine and purify the material inclination. Hence the attitude toward excessive expansion in the material domain remains suspicious and reserved — and we find concepts such as "sanctify yourself even in what is permitted to you,"[28] "they should not be as accustomed to their wives as roosters,"[29] and caution against gluttonous eating.[30]

By contrast, on the Sabbath we find a much greater inclination even toward bodily pleasures — the marital relations of Torah scholars from one Sabbath eve to the next, the commandment to eat meat, the obligation of three meals, the enactment of "a stew with extra fat and spiced drink,"[31] and so forth. This phenomenon too is explained in light of the general principle above — behavior on the Sabbath should be a kind of behavior fitting for the repaired reality. In the repaired reality, in which there are no longer fears and sins, in which the venom of the primordial serpent has been removed from man and the bodily inclination has been refined of its dross — there is no longer reservation and retreat from materiality; on the contrary, matters reach a full harmony in which matter and spirit no longer oppose and constrain one another, and matter constitutes a further encounter with divine revelation, a further experience of delighting in God. On the Sabbath, matter and spirit are integrated in peace into a pure and sublime experience of delight.

Universality and particularity: we find in the sources a somewhat dual attitude to the question of whether the Sabbath is a universal concept or one particular to the people of Israel. This is already reflected in the different rationale accompanying the commandment of the Sabbath in the first version of the Ten Commandments as against the last. In the Ten Commandments in the portion of Yitro,[32] the Sabbath is grounded on a universal principle — "for in six days the LORD made the heavens and the earth." By contrast, in the Ten Commandments in the portion of Va'etchanan, the rationale is different: "and you shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt, and the LORD your God brought you

out from there with a mighty hand and an outstretched arm; therefore the LORD your God commanded you to observe the Sabbath day" (Deut. 5:15). It is striking that this rationale is directed at the people of Israel alone, and that according to the last version of the Commandments, the nations have no relation to, or reason for, observing the Sabbath.[33] In the prayer book, this duality finds expression in the Kiddush prayers — in the evening Kiddush we say a universal formula (the passage of Shabbat-Bereishit), while in the morning Kiddush the formula is particular (the passage "and the children of Israel shall keep"[34]), calling the Sabbath a sign between the Holy One and the children of Israel. In halakha we find a central emphasis on the particular facet, to the point that a gentile who keeps the Sabbath is liable to death,[35] while, on the other side, an Israelite who publicly desecrates the Sabbath is considered as a gentile.[36]

The explanation for this relationship begins with understanding the destiny of the people of Israel. According to our faith, the people of Israel are the exclusive path by which the world becomes a place for the indwelling of the Holy One's presence, and only by the power of Israel can the world be brought to the highest summit of its being, to its true purpose. The essence of Israel is the advancement, repair and completion of the world, and complete repair cannot come without the power and divine endowment of Israel. The people of Israel are the vessel for the actualization of the cosmic vision and purpose.[37]

From this the correct key emerges for understanding the seemingly dual relationship of the Sabbath to this issue. On the one hand, the Sabbath is above and beyond the holiness of the people of Israel — as the end surpasses the means. The Sabbath carries a universal, general vision, and reflects a supreme reality in which there will no longer be any need to distinguish and set apart a holy people, in which the whole earth will be filled with the knowledge of God and all of humanity will arrive at its full elevation. Therefore, unlike the festivals, the Sabbath is not conditional upon the people of Israel, and we conclude the blessing "who sanctifies the Sabbath" without mentioning the sanctification of the people of Israel. The holiness of the Sabbath precedes, both chronologically and in spiritual essence, the holiness of the people of Israel.

On the other hand, the nations of the world today have no permission at all to approach the Sabbath. As stated, the purpose of the Sabbath is rest in order to work. The unique delight the Sabbath grants lies in ceasing from the great labor of refining, repairing, building and advancing the world and humanity. The Jew's service of God is goal-directed throughout the days of the week, and on the Sabbath we stop and enter into the experience of the goal itself, as though it were the reality actually in effect. This is the way in which a person merits to see the fruit of his good deeds before they have reached completion, and, out of the rest, happiness and Eden-like devotion he experiences in God, he returns to the sacred labor with burning desire and glowing longing. The attribution of the Sabbath specifically to Israel stems from ethical-essential reasons — only one who labors and toils in the sacred work belongs in the cessation from that work. In the meantime, the axis of redemption's advancement passes exclusively through the people of Israel, its elevation and its repentance, its deeds and the fulfillment of its Torah. A gentile who keeps the Sabbath is

liable to death, since there is in this not merely a lack of belonging but pretension and hypocrisy, in that he ceases from labor in which he never engaged and which is none of his concern. This is also why the Sabbath is called a "sign" between the people of Israel and the Holy One, and this is also the connection between the Sabbath and the Exodus from Egypt, which is, in effect, the birth of the congregation of Israel as a nation. The Sabbath represents the direction and purpose for which the people of Israel were created, and therefore it stands at the foundation of Israelite identity and at the foundation of the bond between the Creator and the nation.

Remembering the Sabbath throughout the days of the week:[38] this commandment is explained simply and logically according to the principle we have set out. The Sabbath expresses the purposive reality, the direction of creation. A person must conduct his life out of anticipation of salvation, out of remembrance of the direction and the vision, and recognition that all particular deeds and commandments are directed toward this long-range process. Remembering the Sabbath day throughout the working days is thus an expression of a purpose-guided consciousness of life, and a lived experience of the actualization of a vision — and in this it is, in effect, itself an actualization, or at least a symbol, of the very purpose of the Sabbath.

Exertion in preparation for the Sabbath:[39] halakha aims to establish, in the Sabbath-observant person, an existential atmosphere as similar as possible to the existential atmosphere of the Sabbath of the future to come, of complete perfection and the end. Part of this matter finds expression in the commandment to exert actual effort in preparations for the Sabbath (even when there is no practical need for it whatsoever).

The purpose of creation is described, according to the Kabbalah, as the absolute delight of created beings.[40] This absolute delight can be given to a created being only if he acquires it through his own deeds and choice, and not as a gift of grace and "bread of shame." The essence of delight includes not devotion alone, but also the sense of self-satisfaction and enjoyment from the product of one's personal labor. True delight is only that which is acquired through effort and travail — "they who sow in tears shall reap in joy" (Ps. 126:5). It follows that even on the Sabbath, in preparation for which one exerts and toils in order to make ready, the delight takes on a deeper meaning, and comes to resemble more closely the supreme delight of complete redemption.

Honoring the Sabbath:[41] when we honor the Sabbath, relate to it as to a queen, and fill it with abundance, delight, aesthetic beauty and all that is good, there enters our hearts an awe of reverence and an appreciation of splendor. An elevated atmosphere is created, and the glory of the Sabbath affects us. Out of the unique experience of honor and splendor, the fitting, delicate approach to the holy is received; there awakens a sense of inner belonging to the complete good, and to the whole reality that appears on the Sabbath, and it is planted deep in the soul. As stated above, this feeling — which floods a person with feelings of holiness and enthusiasm to act, to sanctify, to elevate and to repair — is the purpose of the Sabbath.

The prohibition of labor: in our culture, the most central characteristic of the Sabbath is the prohibitions of labor. Part of the aim of writing this essay was to shift the subject of the prohibitions and their strictness away from the focus of the spiritual agenda of the Sabbath, and to restore the essence and religious experience to their proper place. The starting point is that "remember" (zachor) preceded "keep" (shamor) — that is, the prohibitions on performing labor, and the other laws of the Sabbath, were meant to create the atmosphere, and are essential for this, but they do not constitute the essential subject matter of the commandment of the Sabbath in itself. Nevertheless, if we have set out to formulate an idea that tries to touch the essential root of the commandment of the Sabbath, we must find a persuasive explanation even for its basic particulars — the laws of Sabbath observance.

Before attempting to explain the halakhot, we should preface with a caution: even those who favor giving reasons for the commandments did not see it as an obligation or a worthwhile matter to explain the particulars of the commandments, and even regarded such an engagement as disgraceful,[42] but only the reason for the commandment in its generality. This teaches us that there is a real problem in bringing the idea down to the depth of each and every particular, and the rationales for the particulars of a commandment will always be at some remove from the general idea of the commandment. Nevertheless, it is fitting to seek an explanation for the general halakhic principles nonetheless, even if from this point onward halakha develops and branches out with tools unique to itself, and not necessarily by force of adherence to the rationale and reason of the commandment.

By simple intuition we all understand why there is a prohibition of labor on the Sabbath. We recognize the fact that without the prohibition of labor the Sabbath would have no discernible character, and in effect we would find it difficult to experience any kind of unique experience at all, and the Sabbath would resemble every other day of the week. The essence of the experience of holiness is distinction, separation from the mundane. In order to create a meaningful barrier, and thereby to define the Sabbath as an exceptional day, or as a holy day, we must set ourselves apart from certain domains and define them as forbidden and set aside. We understand, then, that in order to establish so dramatic an experience of vision and holiness, we must create a wide gap between our weekday world and our Sabbath world.

There are two ways to explain the fact that the labor forbidden on the Sabbath is defined specifically as those thirty-nine well-known categories of labor (avot melakhah), derived from the building of the Tabernacle. The main approach is to argue that this is a practical prohibition, without inherent essence of its own, whose entire purpose is to create the sublime atmosphere and holy air in which the soul can touch the root of the Sabbath and experience it. Along these lines it is argued that one cannot rationally explain how these categories of labor are connected to the idea of the Sabbath as a foretaste of the World to Come, and all we believe is that these are the tools and aids given to us by the Holy One out of sublime divine wisdom and metaphysical knowledge of the ways of the soul. The divine command establishes a fact for us — without the observance of these prohibitions, the soul would be unable to experience the light of the rest and delight of the future to come. Since

we have no true concept of that day-that-is-wholly-long, and are unable to imagine or grasp it, we require a-rational divine guidance to warn us against those deeds that would harm and desecrate the true experience of the Sabbath. One could also argue that, at our current human level, these labors are bound up for us, in the world of inner-psychic imagery, with the mundane, and that the Torah, in its penetrating vision, revealed this secret to us for our life and our merit. Of course, these claims can be neither proven nor disproven by empirical means; all that remains for us is to try to connect to the experience of the Sabbath, and, out of a stance of faith, to adopt this point of view in an existential sense.

The second approach is to see the thirty-nine categories of labor as a definition that is, at its root, symbolic. The forbidden labor of the Sabbath was defined as those labors performed in the building and operation of the Tabernacle. In this the Torah teaches us about the essence of the Sabbath — on the Sabbath we do not build the holy, we do not create and innovate in the world, we do not repair the world. There is no labor, only the receiving of reward. There is no building and consecrating — everything is already fully built and unified with the holy. We do not act toward the indwelling of the Divine Presence, but rather describe a state in which the Divine Presence already dwells in everything, and we delight in it and live within it. Therefore one must not, on the Sabbath, engage in labors whose concern is the building or work of the Tabernacle — the Tabernacle, the temporary dwelling-place of the Divine Presence, is already built, and spread eternally over all parts of both material and spiritual reality.

F. Summary

In this essay we have tried to locate the single essential point underlying the Sabbath. Despite the presumption involved, our claim has been that the formulation of such a point will be more credible the more it stands up to the test of "inductive generality" — that is, the more it succeeds in demonstrating its essential connection to the greatest possible number of significant particulars touching on the subject, and in persuading that it is built out of attentive observation of these particulars, rather than out of an illumination and direction of thought detached from the whole. This holds for any subject or commandment, and it holds for the Sabbath.

Our central claim regarding the Sabbath has been that the essence of the Sabbath is "a foretaste of the World to Come" — that is, a day in which the character of complete and sublime redemption shines forth. The Sabbath is a real glimmer of the end of days, in which God's kingship will be one and absolute over all the earth, in which the whole of being will reach its completion and arrive at full repair, at the purpose for which it was created, in which it cleaves to and delights in God. The commandment of the Sabbath thus comes to grant a person a deep and unique experience of "tasting" this supreme reality for which the soul longs, and thereby to energize a person toward the six working days and to plant within him renewed powers of anticipation, longing and will to repair, to advance, to elevate, to perform the sacred work and to raise up reality.

We have illustrated our claim through various matters in which the Sabbath is distinguished and characterized. Of course, this survey cannot encompass all the various particulars, nor can it base the idea upon a great many aggadot. We have not brought all the sources and points that reinforce, or at least are consistent with, the argument, and it is even reasonable that we are not yet familiar with all of them. For the sake of an initial grounding, we have touched upon certain characteristics and emphases of the Sabbath — rest; joy and delight; the weighty halakhic significance as a national marker; the suppression of sorrow, petitions, supplications and mourning; "a day that is wholly Sabbath and rest for life everlasting"; the additional soul; the commandment of honoring the Sabbath; "a remembrance of the act of creation"; the thirty-nine categories of labor of the work of the Tabernacle; a sign between Israel and the Holy One; the commandment of remembering the Sabbath; the addition of materiality; "he who exerted himself on the eve of the Sabbath shall eat on the Sabbath"; and so on.[43]

This essay is a further attempt that strives to take part in the great challenge of unifying particulars and principles in the world of Torah. Our great hope is that, despite the fact that the thesis itself may be subject to dispute regarding its generality and scope, we have succeeded in kindling a spark of an idea that will contribute to the experience of the Sabbath in a more essential and meaningful way, and will even spur those who engage with Torah to develop general ideas that will help us descend into the inner depths of the commandments, and thereby experience them in a more elevated and comprehensive manner.

"May the Merciful One bequeath us a day that is wholly Sabbath and rest for life everlasting."

* * *

Notes

1. For clarification: throughout this essay we are asking, in parallel, two closely related but different questions — the question of the essence of the Sabbath day and the question of the purpose of the Sabbath day. The essence is the distinctive or metaphysical character of the Sabbath, its own real quality. The purpose is the reason for the commandment of the Sabbath — what such a day comes to shape within us, for what purpose it was created, what we take from it for our religious existence. These two questions bear a strong and essential connection.
2. We are not speaking of the presentation of the homily or idea (the presentation), but mainly of its construction and preparation in the creative mind of the preacher or thinker. The presentation is a matter of method, and generally does not attest to the mode of thinking.
3. For clarification: this is not a critique of a non-literal reading of sources. This is a legitimate way of expanding an idea and of Torah creativity anchored in tradition. See the introduction to *Ein Ayah*, p. 14, on the method of "elucidation."
4. P. 107.
5. The claim that the foundational path of Judaism should be learned from halakha was stressed a great deal in the teaching of Rav Soloveitchik. See, for example, *Ha-Adam Ve-Olam*, p. 20: "...we must turn to those sources in which Judaism in its purity is dominant, and these are the sources of

halakha. On the original Jewish halakha one can and should rely; it was disconnected from the outside world and was not much influenced by external factors... the Jewish outlook finds clear expression specifically in halakha."

6. The reason for this, beyond the important considerations of the essay's clarity, lies in the existence of a "leap" that is difficult to trace, arising from inspiration, from the study of as many sources as possible, up to the appearance of a general idea that weaves the particulars together.

7. See Rambam, Hilkhhot Shabbat 30:15: "The Sabbath and idolatry are each equivalent to all the other commandments of the Torah combined, and the Sabbath is the sign between the Holy One and us forever; therefore, whoever transgresses the other commandments is counted among the wicked of Israel, but one who desecrates the Sabbath in public is like one who worships idols, and both are considered as gentiles in every respect."

8. This distinction is formulated and clothed in various and numerous forms and diverse phrasings. The terms "a law in the object" (din be-cheftza) and "a law in the person" (din be-gavra), and the various inquiries in the later authorities regarding the status of commandments in light of these terms, are directed around the very question we have posed. See on this a summary, analysis and comparison to Kantian philosophical terms ("phenomena" and "noumena") in: Two Chariots and a Hot-Air Balloon, Rav Michael Avraham, p. 38 (note 1).

9. See Shemot Rabbah, Parashah 15: "'This month shall be unto you' — the ministering angels said before the Holy One: Master of the Universe, when do You make the appointed times? For it is written, 'the matter is by the decree of the watchers.' He said to them: I and you agree on what Israel finalizes and intercalates the year, as it is said, 'I will call upon God Most High, upon God who accomplishes it for me,' and likewise it says, 'these are the appointed seasons of the LORD, holy convocations,' etc. — whether in their proper time or not in their proper time, I have no appointed times but these."

10. See Pesachim 117b.

11. Bereishit Rabbah, Parashah 11, s.v. "a certain philosopher": "Rather, everything that was created during the six days of creation requires further doing — such as mustard, which needs sweetening; lupins, which need sweetening; wheat, which needs grinding; even man needs finishing."

12. "During the six days of creation the Creator did not deliberately complete everything in the work of creation. The Creator laid the foundation, formed the shape, planted the forces, established the laws of nature; yet He left flaws and matters still requiring completion and repair... It is said, 'And God divided the light from the darkness' (Gen. 1:4) — yet He did not entirely abolish the darkness itself... Man's mission, in the capacity of a creator, is to continue the process from the point where it stopped... The Holy One deliberately did not entirely abolish evil, but rather so that man would be active. 'In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth' — the Holy One made only the beginning, while the completion is the task of man" (Rav Soloveitchik, Yemei Zikaron, pp. 86–88).

13. This is likewise reflected in the statement of our Sages that the name of the Messiah preceded the world, that repentance preceded the world, and that the Torah preceded the world. See Midrash Tanchuma (Buber), Parashat Naso, siman 19, s.v. "vayehi bayom."

14. Rav Saadia Gaon and Ibn Ezra explain the words "and the heavens and the earth were finished" as meaning: were completed, brought to completion. See also Radak (on chapter 2, verse 1): "and they were all completed on the sixth day, and from then on nothing new was made, except for things done by way of miracle."

15. God's "resting" from all His work is understood by us as the absolute cessation of everything that comes by the power of God: all creation, all creatures, and especially man, the bearer of choice

and will. Here we are speaking of man as, in a sense, God's replacement, taking up the burden of advancing creation on the one hand (by dint of being "the image of God"), and, on the other hand, as part of the divine essence and its manifestation (by dint of being "a portion of God from above").

16. Mishnah, Tamid 7:4.

17. See, for example, Chizkuni on Genesis 2:4; Ish Ha-Emunah, p. 13.

18. Many sources attest to the use of "Sabbath" to describe redemption and the end of days (see note 16 above). A clear example of this is in the famous liturgical poem of Rabbi Shlomo Alkabetz: "Lecha Dodi likrat kallah, penei Shabbat nekabelah" ("Come, my beloved, to meet the bride; let us welcome the presence of the Sabbath"). The refrain of this poem is a deliberately double-meaning phrase — alongside the call to go out to greet the Sabbath Queen, there is here a prayer to the Holy One (the "beloved") to come to meet the congregation of Israel (the "bride"), so that they may delight together in complete redemption ("let us welcome the presence of the Sabbath"). In light of this duality one can also explain the aggadah describing two angels who accompany a person on Sabbath eve from synagogue to his home; see Shabbat 119b.

19. See Psalms 8:6–7: "For You have made him but little lower than God, and have crowned him with glory and honor. You have made him to have dominion over the works of Your hands; You have put all things under his feet." See note 15 above.

20. Because of the double meaning discussed above, let us clarify that from here on, every use of the word "Sabbath" refers to its simple meaning — the seventh, sanctified day of each week — unless stated otherwise.

21. The central idea of the essence and purpose of the Sabbath is presented here as a conclusion drawn from the examination of the passage of the seventh day of creation, but it stands on its own even if one does not accept at all the exegetical arguments of the previous chapter. See note 6 above.

22. See Otzar Ha-Midrashim (Eisenstein), p. 439, s.v. "and after him they brought out"; and also the Kuzari, Fifth Discourse, section 10. The use of the phrase "World to Come" in this essay refers to redemption and the complete end, and not to the reality or place to which the soul arrives after its life in the body. In the language of our Sages the phrase is used in both senses.

23. See Mishnah, Ta'anit 4:3: "And they would not fast on the eve of the Sabbath, out of honor for the Sabbath, nor on Sunday, so that they should not go directly from rest and delight to exertion and fasting and die." See also Yerushalmi Berakhot, chapter 7, halakhah 4: "If one forgot and did not mention the Sabbath [in Grace after Meals], he says, 'who has given rest to His people Israel.'"

24. "For Reish Lakish said: an additional soul is given to a person on Sabbath eve, and at the Sabbath's departure it is taken from him, as it is said, 'He rested and was refreshed [vayinafash]' — once the Sabbath departs, that additional soul [nefesh] is lost" (Ta'anit 27b).

25. Rambam, Hilkhhot Shabbat 30:12: "It is forbidden to fast, to cry out, to beseech, and to ask for mercy on the Sabbath, even in the case of a calamity for which the community would ordinarily fast and sound the alarm — one does not fast or sound the alarm on the Sabbath or on festivals..."

26. See Responsa Divrei Yatziv, Even HaEzer, siman 75, which discusses this subject at length, and concludes that the mere mention of sins is forbidden, but that when one is doing teshuvah and wishes to confess his sin, it is permitted, since this is akin to the saving of a life.

27. Isaiah 25:8.

28. Yevamot 20a.

29. See Berakhot 22a.

30. See, for example, Horayot 10b: "A parable of two people who roasted their Paschal offerings: one ate it for the sake of the commandment, and one ate it for the sake of gluttonous eating. The

one who ate it for the sake of the commandment — 'the righteous shall walk in them'; the one who ate it for the sake of gluttonous eating — 'and transgressors shall stumble in them.'"

31. See Rambam, *Hilkhot Shabbat* 30:7.

32. See section D above.

33. Our words agree with the Kli Yakar on Parashat Yitro (Exodus 20:8). The Kli Yakar explains that the various differences between the wording of the first version of the Ten Commandments and the wording of the last version (that is, the one appearing in Parashat Va'etchanan) stem from the fact that the Holy One offered the first Commandments to every nation and tongue to accept upon themselves, as the well-known midrash states. For our purposes, what matters is that the Kli Yakar too agrees with our claim that the wording of the first Commandments is a wording that could be accepted by the nations as a whole and obligate them in the commandment of the Sabbath.

34. Exodus 31:16–17.

35. Sanhedrin 58b.

36. See note 7 above.

37. This idea begins with God's blessing to Abraham: "and in you shall all the families of the earth be blessed, and in your seed" (Gen. 28:14). See Orot, "Le-Mahalakh Ha-Ide'ot Be-Yisrael," chapter 2 (p. 104).

38. "Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy' — you shall remember it from the first day of the week, so that if a fine portion comes your way, you shall set it aside in honor of the Sabbath. Rabbi Yitzchak says: you shall not count the days as others count them, but you shall count them for the sake of the Sabbath." (Mekhilta de-Rabbi Yishmael, Yitro, Parashah 7, s.v. "zachor ve-shamor")

39. "Even if a person is very important, and it is not his custom to purchase things from the market or to engage in household labors, he is obligated to personally attend to matters needed for the Sabbath, for this is his honor. Among the early sages, some would chop wood to cook with it, some would cook or salt meat or braid wicks or light lamps, and some would go out and buy the things needed for the Sabbath — food and drink — even though it was not their custom to do so; and whoever increases in this matter is praiseworthy" (Rambam, *Hilkhot Shabbat* 30:6).

40. See *Derekh Hashem* by the Ramchal, part 1, chapter 2 — "On the Purpose of Creation" — and chapter 3 — "On the Human Species."

41. "What is this 'honor' that the Sages spoke of, that it is a commandment upon a person to wash his face, hands and feet in hot water on the eve of the Sabbath, out of honor for the Sabbath... And part of the honor of the Sabbath is that one should wear clean clothing, and one's weekday garment should not be like one's Sabbath garment... A person arranges his table on the eve of the Sabbath, even though he needs no more than an olive's bulk... and one must set his house in order while it is still day, out of honor for the Sabbath, so that there will be a lit candle, a set table and a made bed, for all these are in honor of the Sabbath" (Rambam, *Hilkhot Shabbat* 30:2–5).

42. "...and what is constantly said about this is that everything has a reason, and the reason that became clear to Solomon is the benefit of that commandment in general, and one should not inquire into its particulars" (Guide of the Perplexed, part 3, chapter 26; see there the whole chapter, especially from the words "but I have found a saying of the Sages," etc.).

43. There are further matters and sources that we have not touched upon, for reasons of space and a wish for brevity — such as the emphasis on thanksgiving and praise as the essence of the day ("A psalm, a song for the Sabbath day; it is good to give thanks unto the LORD, and to sing praises unto Your name, O Most High," Ps. 92:1), the fact that the Sabbath serves as the basic model from which the practice of festivals is derived (a claim that requires its own clarification and grounding), the subject of the addition to the Sabbath, and so forth. Our aim is to leave the idea grounded in

principle, but not to foreclose possibilities for further development and refinement, or for drawing varied conclusions.